However, there is no rule to decide which syllable should be stressed in a polysyllabic word (word with more than one syllable). They have to be learnt consciously using a dictionary.

Lexical words (nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs) are stressed.

Grammatical words (auxiliaries, prepositions, pronouns, articles) do not receive any stress.

In words with **weak suffixes,** the root of the word is stressed.

Compound Nouns take the stress on the first syllable.

Compound adjectives take the stress on the second syllable.

Compound Verbs take the stress on the second syllable.

Inflectional words do not change their stress pattern even after the suffix is added.

Derivational words change from parts of speech to another and so their utterance varies and so does the stress.

Words ending with **-ic, -sion, -tion** are stressed on the penultimate syllable. (second from the end).

Words ending with **-cy, -ty, -phy, -gy -al** are stressed on the ante-penultimate syllable. (third from the end)

Syllable stress is usually indicated by a (')mark over the syllable, as is seen in dictionaries. In the above examples, the spellings that represent the syllables are highlighted.

In sentences, we stress only some words and pronounce them louder than the others. By emphasising on a particular word, we can add/ modify the meaning of the sentence. Note that the basic meaning of the sentence does not undergo any change.

Look at the following example.

I gave her an apple yesterday.

See how the sentence gains in meaning by changing the stress from one word to another.

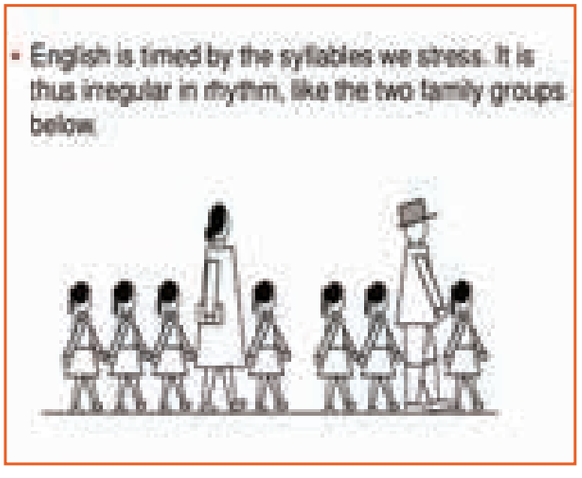
I gave her an apple yesterday. (Only I gave, not somebody else)

I **gave** her an apple yesterday. (gave, not bought)

I gave **her** an apple yesterday. (her and not somebody else)

I gave her an **apple** yesterday. (apple not banana)

I gave her an apple **yesterday**. (yesterday, not any other time)



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